

PAINTING ON A TONED GROUND

THE GREAT ADVANTAGE of working on a toned or colored ground is the economy it can bring to your painting technique. Paint darker tones in transparent colors, which allow the ground color to show through, and lighter tones in opaque colors, which obliterate it. The mid-tones are provided by the color

of the ground itself, so that you soon have a work with a very finished appearance. It would take much longer to reach the same point working on a white ground. The Yellow Ochre mid-toned ground used in the exercise below provides a warm underlying tone for the work and acts as a unifying element in the painting.

PREPARING A TONED GROUND

There are two ways of coloring a ground – either by laying a thin transparent veil of color over the white priming (this is known as an imprimatura) – or by laying an opaque layer of color over the primer. Allow plenty of time for the color to dry before painting.

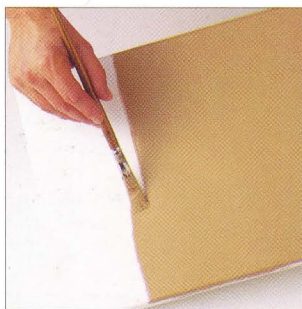


1 A toned ground can be any color, but warm red ochres and browns can give more richness to a work. A thin transparent wash of imprimatura can be made by mixing Burnt Umber and Yellow Ochre and adding turpentine to reduce the paint mixture to a thin consistency. Apply the imprimatura freely and evenly over the support, in this case a panel, with a large bristle brush.



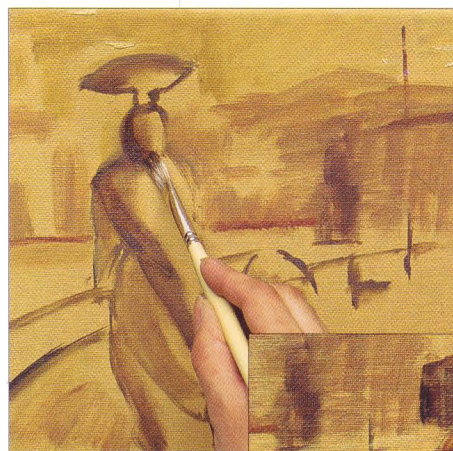
2 Let the solvent in the mixture evaporate for a few minutes, and then rub the surface with a cloth to take away the excess paint. This means that the white priming has a stain of transparent color rather than a coat of paint. The main advantage of using an imprimatura rather than a toned ground is that the film of color allows the white of the original priming to retain its reflective quality on the colors painted over it.

The opaqueness of a colored ground ensures a complete uniformity of tone over the surface of the support. A colored ground can also be laid by mixing color in with the primer itself before it is applied.



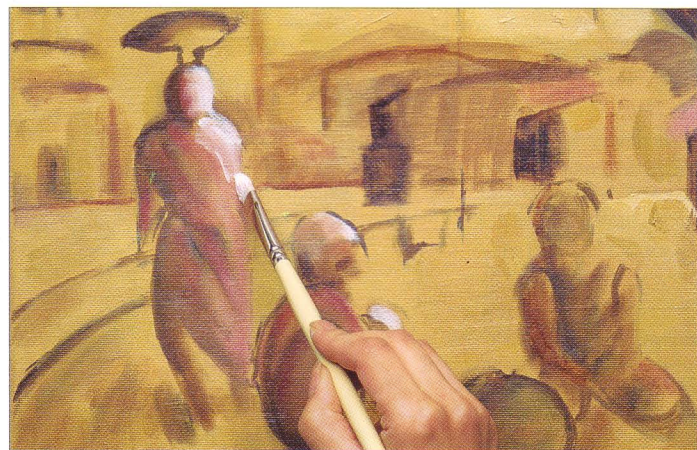
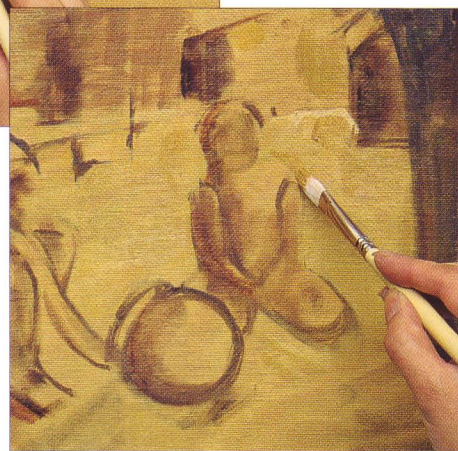
Toning a primed canvas

This canvas support has already been primed with white primer, and a colored ground made of Burnt Umber, Yellow Ochre, and Titanium White is laid over the top with a large wash brush. A colored ground will take longer to dry than an imprimatura, so ensure that it is completely dry before you begin to paint. Most colored grounds will take a few days to dry completely.



1 Sketch in the composition with a medium-sized bristle brush and a thin mix of Burnt Umber. The ground has been prepared with a mix of Yellow Ochre, Gold Ochre, and Titanium White.

2 Break up and enliven areas of the colored ground using a medium-sized bristle brush and a slightly thicker mixture of Yellow Ochre with a touch of Titanium White and Cadmium Red.



3 Once you have blocked in all the shapes and dark areas of shadow with thin color, start to build up the highlights on each figure using a thick, dry mix of Titanium White, Alizarin Crimson, and Yellow Ochre and a medium-sized filbert bristle brush.